Happy Together

ROHAN KANAWADE'S TENDER GAY ROMANCE, *SABAR BONDA*, HAS WON THE TOP JURY PRIZE IN THE WORLD CINEMA SECTION AT THE SUNDANCE FILM FESTIVAL

When interior designer-turned-filmmaker Rohan Kanawade decided he'd come out to his parents, he was anxious and expected a showdown. Instead, his father, a driver, and homemaker mother embraced him for who he was. "My semi-literate father said, 'You know about yourself and that's what's important'," recalls Kanawade. "They were so positive. I was like why do we only see tragic tales about us [LGBTQ] in films, why don't we see this?" In his first feature *Sabar Bonda*, which is in Marathi and has just bagged the World Cinema Grand Jury Prize at the Sundance Film Festival, he doesn't recreate the scene but channelises that sentiment with a mother who supports her son as his relatives corner him to get married.

Kanawade's film, whose title alludes to the cactus pear, echoes Martin Scorcese's famous diktat: the personal is universal. Shot in his maternal village Kharshinde in Maharashtra, the film centres around Anand (Bhushaan Manoj) who arrives at his ancestral place for his father's last rites. A 10-day grieving period follows during which he reconnects with his friend, Balya (Suraaj Suman), and a tender romance blossoms. In a lovely moment, Anand receives the juicy, red fruit with its spines removed and savours it, reliving a fond childhood memory. For Kanawade, the title is a metaphor for the lives of his two leads—"that even in a harsh landscape, something grows, and that these two men despite their hardships stay true to their identity," he explains.

Kanawade knew that finding funding for his tale would be as prickly as peeling the fruit. "The vision we had for this film, I felt no one is going to support it," he says. "I also didn't want any interference." He found his first producer in London-based Neeraj Churi, who had also backed his short, *U for Usha* (2019), and then turned to crowd-funding from his queer friends based abroad. Three of them would come forward along with Bridge PostWorks, which would help with the post-production. Kanawade also travelled with the script to multiple screenwriting labs and co-production markets to build "visibility". "Labs gave us confidence that people are responding to the script. I am not a trained filmmaker, so I felt insight from mentors will help me hone my craft," he says.

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A self-taught filmmaker, **KANAWADE** learned by making shorts, reading scripts and watching interviews of directors and making-of segments